

SME AI READINESS PLAYBOOK

A Practical Guide for Business Owners
Ready to Stop Guessing and Start Automating.

40

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This playbook is for the SME owner who keeps hearing about AI, maybe tried a few tools, and still isn't sure whether their business is ready — or what "ready" even looks like. By the end, you'll know exactly where you stand, what's holding you back, and what to do next.

01

Why Most AI Implementations Fail

And how to be different.

Most small and medium businesses that "try AI" fail at it — not because AI doesn't work, but because they go about it backwards. They see a LinkedIn post, sign up for three tools, spend a weekend tinkering, get underwhelming results, and conclude that AI isn't really for businesses like theirs. That's the wrong conclusion. The right conclusion is: AI requires a foundation.

The Real Reasons AI Fails in Small Business

01 Wrong starting point

Businesses try to automate whatever is top of mind — usually something frustrating but not actually high-value. You can't automate your way out of a process problem.

02 Data is a mess

AI tools are only as smart as the data you feed them. If your customer records live in three spreadsheets and your CRM is half-updated, you're building on sand.

03 Team wasn't brought along

Resistance and quiet sabotage are almost guaranteed when AI tools appear without explanation. When leadership doesn't communicate clearly, fear wins.

04 Wrong expectations

AI is not magic. Business owners who expect a \$99/month tool to replace a full-time employee and triple revenue in 90 days will be disappointed every single time.

05 No one driving it

Every successful AI implementation has had a champion — one person whose job it is to shepherd the change, troubleshoot, and keep momentum going.

Businesses That Get It Right

The pattern behind every successful SME AI adoption.

- Start with a clear problem to solve, not a tool to try
- Prepare their data and processes before switching anything on
- Communicate openly with their team about what's changing and why
- Set realistic 90-day goals and measure against them
- Get help when they need it rather than burning months figuring it out alone

A Note on Language

Throughout this playbook, "AI" refers broadly to artificial intelligence tools — including large language models like Claude and ChatGPT, automation platforms like Zapier and Make, and AI agents capable of multi-step autonomous actions. Everything is explained as we go — no assumed knowledge required.

02

The AI Readiness Score

Your 20-question self-assessment across 5 dimensions.

How It Works

20 questions across 5 dimensions (4 questions each). Each answer is worth 0, 1, or 2 points. Maximum possible score: 40 points. Your total places you in one of four readiness levels. Answer honestly — the score is only useful if it's accurate.

DIMENSION 1

Data Quality — How clean, organised, and accessible is your business data?

Q1 Where does your customer data live?

- ☐ (0) It's spread across emails, spreadsheets, sticky notes, and memory. No single source of truth.
- ☐ (1) We have a CRM or database, but it's partially filled in and not regularly maintained.
- ☒ (2) We have a CRM or central system that's reasonably complete, regularly updated, and used by the team.

Score: ____

Q2 How consistent is your data entry across the business?

- ☐ (0) Everyone does it differently. No standard.
- ☐ (1) We have some guidelines but they're not enforced. Data quality varies a lot.
- ☒ (2) We have clear standards and most of the team follows them consistently.

Score: ____

DIMENSION 1

Data Quality (continued)

Q3 Could you pull a reliable customer list with purchase history in under 10 minutes?

- ☐ (0) No. It would take significant time and effort, and still wouldn't be fully reliable.
- ☐ (1) Probably, but it would need cleaning and cross-referencing from several sources.
- ☒ (2) Yes — we could do this quickly and trust the output.

Score: ____

Q4 How long do you retain and organise historical business data?

- ☐ (0) We don't really have a retention policy. Old data is either lost or buried somewhere inaccessible.
- ☐ (1) We keep data, but it's not well organised or easily searchable.
- ☒ (2) We keep at least 12 months of clean historical data that's accessible and easy to query.

Score: ____

Dimension 1 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 2

Process Documentation — How well-defined are your core business processes

Q5 How are your core business processes documented?

- ☐ (0) They live in people's heads. Nothing is written down in any formal way.
- ☐ (1) Some key processes are documented, but it's patchy — maybe a few rough SOPs.
- ☒ (2) Most core processes are documented clearly enough that a new employee could follow them.

Score: ____

Q6 If your most experienced employee left tomorrow, how much knowledge would walk out the door?

- ☐ (0) A huge amount. Critical processes and relationships are entirely in one person's head.
- ☐ (1) Some. We'd struggle but we'd figure it out eventually.
- ☒ (2) Manageable. Key knowledge is documented and systems are shared.

Score: ____

DIMENSION 2

Process Documentation (continued)

Q7 Can you describe, step-by-step, how a new customer inquiry becomes a closed sale?

- ☐ (0) Not really. It varies a lot depending on who handles it.
- ☐ (1) Mostly yes, but there are gaps and inconsistencies.
- ☒ (2) Yes — we have a defined process and it's followed consistently.

Score: ____

Q8 How often do things "fall through the cracks" in your business?

- ☐ (0) Often. Dropped leads, missed follow-ups, forgotten tasks are a regular occurrence.
- ☐ (1) Sometimes. It's not a constant problem but it happens more than it should.
- ☒ (2) Rarely. We have systems that catch things before they fall through.

Score: ____

Dimension 2 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 3

Team Readiness — How prepared is your team for AI-driven change?

Q9 How would you describe your team's general attitude toward new technology?

- ☐ (0) Resistant. New tools are typically met with complaints and avoidance.
- ☐ (1) Mixed. Some people embrace it, others drag their heels.
- ☒ (2) Generally open. The team understands that adapting to new tools is part of the job.

Score: ____

Q10 Have you successfully implemented a new software tool or system in the last 12 months?

- ☐ (0) No, or we tried and it didn't stick.
- ☐ (1) Yes, but it was harder than expected and adoption was partial.
- ☒ (2) Yes — we rolled it out successfully and the team uses it consistently.

Score: ____

DIMENSION 3

Team Readiness (continued)

Q11 Does someone in your business have time and interest to champion an AI initiative?

- ☐ (0) No. Everyone is already stretched and no one is positioned to lead this.
- ☐ (1) Maybe. There's interest but no clear time or ownership.
- ☒ (2) Yes — there's a clear person who could own this and has the capacity to drive it.

Score: ____

Q12 How does your team respond to process changes and new ways of working?

- ☐ (0) Poorly. Change is resisted and often quietly ignored.
- ☐ (1) Okay. There's some friction but people generally come around.
- ☒ (2) Well. The team is adaptable and changes are adopted with reasonable speed.

Score: ____

Dimension 3 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 4

Tech Stack — Are your current tools AI-ready?

Q13 Does your business use a CRM (customer relationship management) system?

- ☐ (0) No. Customer information is managed through email, spreadsheets, or memory.
- ☐ (1) Yes, but it's not consistently used or regularly maintained.
- ☒ (2) Yes — we use it consistently and it holds reliable, up-to-date information.

Score: ____

Q14 How integrated are your core business tools with each other?

- ☐ (0) Not at all. Everything is siloed and people manually copy data between systems.
- ☐ (1) Partially. Some things connect, but there's still a lot of manual work.
- ☒ (2) Well connected. Key tools talk to each other and data flows without manual intervention.

Score: ____

DIMENSION 4

Tech Stack (continued)

Q15 Are you currently using any automation tools (Zapier, Make, n8n, or similar)?

- ☐ (0) No.
- ☐ (1) We've tried one or two things but nothing is consistently running.
- ☒ (2) Yes — we have active automations that are working reliably.

Score: ____

Q16 How would you rate your business's overall digital maturity?

- ☐ (0) Low. We're still relying heavily on paper, phone calls, and manual processes.
- ☐ (1) Moderate. We use digital tools but there's significant room to improve.
- ☒ (2) High. Our operations are largely digital, with good data hygiene and modern tools.

Score: ____

Dimension 4 Total: ____ / 8

DIMENSION 5

Budget Realism — Are you ready to invest appropriately?

Q17 What is your realistic budget for AI tools and implementation in the next 12 months?

- ☐ (0) Under \$500. We're really just looking for free options.
- ☐ (1) \$500–\$3,000. Willing to pay for tools that clearly deliver ROI.
- ☒ (2) \$3,000+. We understand this is an investment and have allocated real budget.

Score: ____

Q18 Do you have budget allocated for external help (consulting, implementation, training)?

- ☐ (0) No. We expect to figure this out entirely in-house.
- ☐ (1) Possibly. We'd consider it if the value was clear.
- ☒ (2) Yes — we understand the value of expertise and have budget for external support.

Score: ____

DIMENSION 5

Budget Realism (continued)

Q19 How do you typically evaluate the ROI of a new business investment?

- ☐ (0) We don't really. Decisions are mostly gut-feel.
- ☐ (1) Informally. We think about it but don't measure rigorously.
- ☒ (2) Formally. We set clear success metrics upfront and measure outcomes.

Score: ____

Q20 What is your timeline expectation for seeing meaningful results from AI investment?

- ☐ (0) 30 days. I need to see results immediately or it's not worth it.
- ☐ (1) 3–6 months. I understand there's a ramp-up period.
- ☒ (2) 6–12 months. I'm investing for sustainable outcomes, not quick wins.

Score: ____

Dimension 5 Total: ____ / 8

YOUR TOTAL SCORE

____ / 40

Add all 5 dimension totals above

03

Scoring Your Results

What your score actually means.

0–14 Pre-Ignition

Your business isn't ready for AI implementation yet — and that's completely fine. This is the most common starting point. The right move is to focus on the fundamentals: clean up your data, document your key processes, and build the digital foundation that makes everything else possible. Start with Section 6's 90-Day Roadmap.

15–24 Building Runway

You have some foundations in place but meaningful gaps remain. You could implement simple, standalone automations now — and you should. But hold off on anything complex until your data and processes are stronger. Focus on the dimensions where you scored lowest first.

25–33 Ready to Launch

Your business is well-positioned to implement AI effectively. You have the data, processes, and team readiness to support meaningful automation. Move methodically: start with your highest-ROI opportunities and build from there.

34–40 Ignition

You're in excellent shape. Your business has the foundation, the team, and the budget to move fast. The risk now is overcomplicating things — resist the urge to implement everything at once. Prioritise ruthlessly and execute well.

06

Your 90-Day AI Readiness Roadmap

What to do in the next 90 days, regardless of your score.

Days 1-30

Foundation

Score your results. Identify your lowest dimension. Document your top 3 most important processes. Audit your data sources and pick one system to become your source of truth. Get the team briefed: what AI is, what you're planning, and what's changing (and not changing) about their roles.

Days 31-60

First Automation

Implement one automation — just one. Choose the highest-frequency manual task with a consistent trigger. Measure the time saved. Fix any issues. Document what you built. Build confidence before adding complexity.

Days 61-90

Expand and Assess

Review what you've built. If it's working, add your second automation. If your score was under 25, re-assess: have the foundations improved? Consider your next 90-day cycle. Decide whether you need external help for the next phase.

Tool Stack Recommendations by Budget

Honest recommendations — no affiliate links, no hype.

\$0-\$500/month

Starting Out

- ChatGPT Free or Claude Free for content and analysis
- Zapier Free (100 tasks/month) for basic automations
- Google Workspace for documents, email, and collaboration
- Notion Free for process documentation
- Google Analytics 4 for website and ecommerce tracking

\$500-\$2,000/month

Building Momentum

- ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro (\$20/month) — worth it
- Zapier Starter (\$29.99/month) or Make Core (\$16/month)
- A proper CRM: HubSpot Starter or Pipedrive Essential
- Loom for async video — reduces meeting load significantly
- Consider a dedicated AI writing tool if content volume is high

\$2,000+/month

Scaling Seriously

- Anthropic API or OpenAI API for custom AI integrations
- n8n self-hosted or Make Business for complex workflows
- Enterprise CRM with AI features (HubSpot Pro, Salesforce)
- Custom AI agents for your specific use cases
- Dedicated analytics and BI tooling (Looker Studio, Metabase)

AI Prompt Library

10 ready-to-use prompts to start getting value today.

#01 Summarise a meeting

Paste the transcript or notes below and summarise the key decisions, action items, and owners. Format as a bulleted list.

#02 Draft a client email

Write a professional email to [client name] following up on [meeting/proposal/project]. Tone: friendly but direct. Length: under 150 words.

#03 Analyse customer feedback

Here are [n] customer reviews. Identify the top 3 positive themes and top 3 complaints. Suggest one improvement based on the complaints.

#04 Write a job description

Write a job description for a [role] at a [type] business with [n] staff. Include responsibilities, requirements, and what makes this role unique.

#05 Create an SOP

Write a step-by-step standard operating procedure for [process]. Include when to use it, who owns it, and what success looks like.

#06 Competitive analysis

Here are three competitors: [A, B, C]. Compare their positioning, pricing model, and apparent target customer. Suggest one gap we could exploit.

#07 Generate FAQ

Generate 8 frequently asked questions a potential customer would ask about [product/service]. Include clear, honest answers for each.

#08 Rewrite for clarity

Rewrite this text to be clearer and more direct. Avoid jargon. Target reading level: Year 10. Keep the meaning identical.

#09 Monthly report template

Create a monthly business performance report template for [type of business]. Include sections for revenue, key metrics, wins, challenges, and next month focus.

#10 Decision framework

Help me think through a decision: [describe decision]. List the key considerations, potential risks, and recommend which option to take and why.

NEXT STEPS

Know Your Score. Now Use It.

Book a free 30-minute discovery call with Ignition Agency. Bring your score. We'll tell you exactly what it means for your business, what to prioritise, and whether we're the right people to help you move forward.

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